Israel used American-made arms for defensive purposes only. “We must come to the diplomatic table for a solution and not through use of military means,” I said. I reminded Begin that only two days earlier George Shultz and I had told Shamir that Habib ‘s negotiations aimed at removing the PLO from Beirut were making progress and were at a critical stage and further attacks could destroy whatever chances of success they had. “Israel’s movement of heavy artillery into West Beirut demonstrated that our message to the Foreign Minister fell on deaf ears. There has to be an end to unnecessary bloodshed, particularly among innocent civilians. I insist that a cease fire be reestablished and maintained until the PLO has left Beirut.”

Begin’s reply the next day stated that Israel’s policy in Lebanon was based on two principles: The first was adherence to the agreed-upon cease-fire provided “it is absolute and mutual, neither of which have been respected by the terrorists in and around Beirut; [we] have already counted at least ten cease-fires and all of them broken by the terrorists, while Israel adhered to the rules.” Begin said that under no circumstances could he “ask members of the Israeli defense forces, if fired upon, to refrain from defending themselves.”

The second principle, Begin said, was achieving a political solution that provided for expulsion of the PLO from Lebanon. He said, however, that Israel had to preserve the choice of a military option because without one it would have no leverage to seek a political solution. The UN resolution calling for its withdrawal and U.S. officials’ statements calling on Israel to leave were encouraging the PLO to procrastinate and refuse to leave. As a result, Israel had to keep up military pressure on the PLO. Begin indicated that he had just received a letter from Philip Habib who had told him there was “increasing evidence” the PLO was prepared to negotiate a withdrawal from Beirut, but then